Music Theory Questions and Analysis: Study Notes

Subject: Comparative Analysis, Examination Inquiries, and Theoretical Solutions

Frequently Asked Questions in Music Theory

Q1: Who is the father of Carnatic music?
Answer: Purandara Dasa (1484–1564) is universally revered as the **Father of Carnatic music** (*Sangeeta Pitamaha*). He earned this title because he systematized the entire pedagogy of Carnatic music (Sarali, Janta, Alankaras, Geethams in Mayamalavagowla), standardized the Suladi Sapta Talas, and composed foundational devotional works.

Q2: What intervals construct a major triad, and what are its scale degrees?
Answer: A major triad consists of a root tone, a major third (4 semitones above the root), and a perfect fifth (7 semitones above the root). In scale degrees, it corresponds to degrees 1, 3, and 5 of the major scale (e.g. C – E – G).

Q3: What is a Perfect Authentic Cadence (PAC) in classical harmony?
Answer: A PAC is a harmonic progression from the Dominant (V) to the Tonic (I) where both chords are in fundamental root position, and the soprano voice terminates on the tonic root pitch (^1). It provides maximum tonal finality.

Q4: Why are parallel fifths and octaves forbidden in classical SATB part writing?
Answer: In classical four-part voice leading, consecutive parallel fifths and octaves between any two voices are strictly prohibited because they destroy the vocal independence of the parts. Composers maintain independence by employing contrary and oblique motion.

Q5: How does 6/8 meter differ from 3/4 meter?
Answer: 6/8 is a compound duple meter containing two dotted-quarter beats per measure, with each beat dividing into three eighth notes. In contrast, 3/4 is a simple triple meter containing three quarter-note beats per measure, each dividing into two eighth notes.

Q6: What is the equivalent of the Western Major Scale in the Carnatic Melakarta system?
Answer: The Western Major scale (diatonic Ionian mode) is identical in interval structure (S R2 G3 M1 P D2 N3 S) to the 29th Melakarta raga, **Dheerasankarabharanam** (commonly known as Shankarabharanam).